Remote authentication is an authentication scheme that utilizes third-party services to help identify whether a user, who tries to log in, has valid credentials prior to entering an authenticated area. By using this scheme to authenticate, users just have to sign in once with third-party providers that provide such services, and then they can sign in to other websites that support remote authentication without supplying their e-mail addresses and passwords anymore.

Popular websites, such as Twitter, Facebook, and even Google, provide remote authentication services to its users. Surely, due to the huge number of users, it would be good if our websites could authenticate its users using only their Twitter, Facebook, or Google accounts.

At this point perhaps you're wondering why big companies like them want to act as remote authentication providers who give authentication services to other websites for free. Isn't that a waste of their bandwidth and resources? That question of course has its own merits. Remote authentication providers won't usually give these services to just anyone. To utilize it, we have to first register our application at their site. This is to ensure that they can track every application that use their services and can provide assistance in case of trouble. They also have the right to reject or ban our application if we misuse or violate their term of rights.

Meanwhile, providing these services also has benefits for them; remember that users have to register a new account at their site before they can authenticate using it? That's an important benefit for them. By providing these services, remote authentication providers can increase their user base.

OmniAuth

Let's now take a closer look at Devise and how it can support remote authentication. By itself, Devise is already customizable enough to enable support for remote authentication. However, Devise doesn't actually have internal functions for this purpose, and as a consequence, we have to do a lot of lifting to build this feature purely using Devise. Therefore, because it is almost always better to "re-use" rather than "build from scratch", let's look into other possible alternatives.

Enter **OmniAuth** (`https://github.com/intridea/omniauth`). If you remember from *Chapter 1*, *Devise – Authentication Solution for Ruby on Rails*, Devise has an `Omniauthable` module that enables Devise to connect with OmniAuth; this is where you will find that ability useful.

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